CHAPTER 31 Language and Racism

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Introduction

This chapter, which looks at some of many tangled and layered connections between language and racism, begins with the introduction of "modern race," by which we mean race and racism within the context of European modernity. Race, the division and classification of humans based on the arbitrary grouping of observable physical traits and notions of ancestry, is a social system (i.e., a broad network of relations and the structures) that has taken many forms throughout human history and often functions as ethnoracial structures situated in a hierarchy.[1] Ethnoracial structures provide political and sociocultural rubrics for sorting people based on physical features and notions of ancestry and are embedded in, and emerge out of, layered histories and structures of power that traverse the local and global, therefore making any instantiation of race inextricable from racism. The term "ethnoracial" takes into account the ways in which structures of difference based on perceived phenotypical variation (race) and structures of difference based on understandings of recent heritage (ethnicity) often bleed into one another and do much of the same sociocultural and political work. And, informed by intersectional theory (Collins 1998; Crenshaw 1989), we understand the ethnoracial as inextricable from gender, sexuality, class, and (dis)ability and the social hierarchies through which they are constructed and lived, even when our discussions do not explicitly parse these dimensions.

The modern social system and construction that many of us identify as "race" is composed of classifications formulated over several historical moments, which may include periods preceding what many refer to as modernity (as well as postmodernity or "late modernity" (Giddens 1991)) but that were formalized during this extensive era.[2] Throughout each of its stages, iterations of biological race (via scientific racism) were generated to eventually produce classifications of humans that have significantly conditioned many aspects of social organization and sociality across historical times and places.

[1] Du Bois 1940/2011; Omi and Winant 2014; Painter 2011.

[2] See Bindman et al. 2010; Heng 2011; Kelley 2017; Makalani 2021; Mills 1997; Painter 2011; Robinson 2000.

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Modern race takes form via colonialism (settler colonialism, especially) and racial slavery (i.e., the Atlantic slave trade), two structural processes animated by capitalism.[3] Together, these structural processes (capitalism, colonialism, and racial slavery) serve as the cognates of what Barnor Hesse described as "racialized modernity" to name the ways in which modernity was always already a racial project (2007). Because modern race has been as widely exported as modernity itself, when studying any aspect of language (formal, functional, or other) in a context that has been informed to any extent by European modernity and the understandings of human(ness) and governance that it violently peddles (namely, around civility and citizenship, sovereignty and nation), it is necessary to have some sense of its prevalent racial ontologies (i.e., categories of racialized subjects/objects) and meanings that have been directly or performatively connected to these categories. In particular, for scholarship concerning language and discourse in the US, or in social spaces impacted by the US, some grappling with the subject categories that emerged in those places from these yoked structural processes of modernity is requisite to avoid reproducing certain harms.

This means acknowledging and sitting with the ways in which modern race helped construct the concepts of "Human," "Savage," "Other," and property and in so doing, effectively produced a racial order in which those racialized as white, or as closest to white in a global context, were positioned at the apex and those who were considered Black (African, "Negro"), or closest to Black, were positioned at the nadir (Wynter 2003), or at the "bottom of the well" (Bell 2018)—a slot sometimes, and uncomfortably, shared with other Indigenous and racialized peoples, depending on geopolitical context. In tandem with racial slavery and its afterlife (Hartman 2007), which constructs Black subjects in the Americas as property (Spillers 1987), the overlapping project of settler colonial dispossession and genocide via European and American colonial regimes racializes Native American populations in the US as "historical, endangered, and artifactual" (Meek 2020). In this ideological framework, Native Americans are imagined as a singular group of people whose characteristics are as much temporal (of the past) as geographic, biological, and linguistic.[4]

These "raciontologies" (Rosa and Diaz 2020) have engendered a popular US praxis of treating Black and Native people and the fruits of our intellectual and creative labor as the property of others—in particular, via linguistic appropriation and ownership through knowledge about our language structures and practices (Davis and Smalls 2021). They also engender a sense of the inalienable right to police Black and Native (and people of color) bodies, movements, and behavior (e.g., regulating language, dress, and other semiotic practices via "Karens"; "Permit Pattys"; vigilantism, etc.). And, these processes of racialization have rendered Native American and Black as not only mutually exclusive categories[5] but also as monolithic categories in which ethnic and national distinctions are effectively erased or deemed irrelevant in the popular imaginary, even regarding language.[6]

While modern race is not a "Black–white binary," as many understand it and take it up, its general hierarchical form does have rather consistent and foregrounded (but not immutable) poles that help organize the global field of racial meaning-making (or, the semiotic processes used to realize and legitimize racialization) and that often get operationalized as a binary. Who is slotted as white or Black, in-between, or something else will vary in

[3] See Du Bois 1904; Hesse 2007; Mills 2003; Painter 2011; Robinson 1983/2000; Williams 1944/2015.

[4] See Byrd 2011; Deloria 2008; O'Brien 2010; TallBear 2003, 2013. For discussion of how these practices were then mobilized globally, see Byrd 2010.

[5] Byrd 2019; King 2019; Leroy 2016.

[6] Byrd 2019; King 2019; Leroy 2016.

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different places and times, and the antipodal categories may only abstractly and/or unconsciously condition the way meaning about being human is made (in the context of global or transnational interaction), even where no Black-identified or white-identified people are present. Therefore, the hierarchical continuum of race as constructed vis-à-vis European modernity is crucially relevant for examining the ways groups are racialized in the US, Europe, throughout the Americas, and elsewhere.

This understanding means that most considerations of race (as racialization, racialism, racial identity, or racism) in and beyond language study demand an engagement with modern race (as a global organizing principle that is always already racist in that it is based on a relatively stable (but not rigidly fixed) racial hierarchy). Alongside several scholars, Arthur Spears has long argued that considering the "macro-contexts" (2019) in which linguistic and discursive processes of racialization emerge is vital for language scholarship intended to be decolonial, anti-racist, or abolitionist.

In the following section, we highlight two central approaches (raciolinguistics and Indigenous and decolonizing approaches) that have helped shape the study of language and racism, and one key concept from the field: "mock language." Following Spears' (2021) and others' calls to attend to the broad structures of race/ism that condition individual, interpersonal, and institutional practice (Hill 2008; Rosa and Díaz 2020), we then apply the approaches and the concept of mock language in a discussion about the gaming universe of World of Warcraft (WoW). In particular, we consider how the discursive practices that constitute much WoW sociality help reproduce modern race/ism (as antiblackness and anti-Nativeness in our inquiry).

Key Approaches and Concepts in the Study of Language and Race/ism

Key Approach: Raciolinguistics

The focused study of the myriad interconnections between language and race—taken up as racialism, racialization, racial identity, or racism—gained prominence in the 1970s (e.g., Labov 1972; Smitherman 1977), and since then, has remained a steadily growing subfield (which encompasses linguistics, anthropology, communications, and cultural studies) despite the US's fickle attention to, and concern with, racial (in)justice. The 2016 volume *Raciolinguistics: How Language Shapes Our Ideas about Race* (edited by H. Samy Alim, John Rickford, and Arnetha Ball) retroactively named and formalized the subfield and, with contributions that have reverberated throughout language studies, helped graph the current raciolinguistic terrain of several nation-states. This pivotal text, alongside the 2020 *Oxford Handbook on Language and Race* (edited by Angela Reyes, H. Samy Alim, and Paul Kroskrity) and the bodies of work that help constitute the subfield, lay bare the willful violences and the unintended harms, erasures, and misconstruals that can emerge when we bypass race in our meaning-making about social kinds, social orders, and social life overall. And, critically, many of these works also examine the ways racially marginalized peoples navigate, resist, and live beyond racist structures and practices.[7]

Naming and Addressing White Supremacy In recent years, an increasing number of studies on language and race/ism have engaged with race scholars' key interventions including those from Black Studies, Ethnic Studies, Native American and Indigenous Studies, Gender and Sexuality Studies, Cultural Studies, anthropology, sociology, education, and history, as well

[7] Smitherman 1977; Morgan 1993; Alim 2004; Rosa 2018; and Smalls forthcoming as a few examples.

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as from interdisciplinary language scholars working in these fields. Together, they help us better understand how individuals' and groups' racialized identities, intentions, feelings, and thoughts are certainly important sites of inquiry, but must be examined within historical, political, and cultural context.[8] They also help us understand how there is no race without racism or its interrelated sociopolitical hierarchies of gender and class, as formulated by the Black Feminist concept of "intersectionality" (Collins 1998; Crenshaw 1989). This approach often takes up intersubjectivity, identity, interpersonal relations and any other phenomena related to person-making not only as relational on the micro-scale of everyday human interaction, but also as contingent upon vast past and present sociopolitical structures. In particular, it considers how people make meaning about selves and others via racial ideologies.

Many of these scholars explicitly cast modern race/ism as White Supremacy and have insisted that we consider the ways it helps shape social life and death. For example, Arthur Spears' game changing edited volume *Race and Ideology: Language, Symbolism, and Popular Culture* (1999) brought together work which modeled a way of thinking about race and language in relation to White Supremacy that was grounded in theory about race produced by scholars from all over the world; addressed wide political, economic, historical context; and acknowledged the interlocking of race and class.

Spears (1999, 2021), Hill (1998, 2008) and others have shown that without a framing that acknowledges the existence and effects of White Supremacy, studies of practices by people who have been constructed as white help position whiteness as an unmarked universal and default human by presenting themselves as studies about "women" or "the working class" or "teachers." As such, racialized phenomena like calling the police on BIPoC (Black, Indigenous, and/or People of Color) people without hesitation, or describing an adult Asian woman as "cute as a button," might be overlooked or considered merely the actions of individuals and not as possible constituents (or products) of whiteness as a social structure.[9] That is to say, scholarship in which a research subject's designation as white (or relationally white, white-adjacent, symbolically white, provisionally white, etc.) is not factored into analyses helps predicate white normativity and thereby holds up one of the bastions of White Supremacy-cum-whiteness-cum-modern race. When juxtaposed to an almost obsessive attention to practices by Black, Indigenous, and people of color over past centuries, practices which are almost always regarded as related to our "culture" or ethnoracial positioning, the "unmarked whiteness approach" risks presenting the practices of racialized others as culturally or community specific (and homogenous) and does not examine how interactions between white and non-white people, institutions, discourses, etc. are embedded in multiscalar systems of power. Following Jane Hill and her steadfast investment in marking whiteness (1995, 1998, 2008), several scholars have also devoted much of their research to examining how whiteness is reproduced via language, discourse, and related policies.[10]

Political anthropologist Faye V. Harrison (1995, p. 49) noted the ways in which "the variation in racial constructions, including the conventionally neglected configurations of whiteness" became an anthropological concern some 20 years ago, and emphasized how complex and interrelated sociopolitical trajectories work together to "encode, hierarchize, and pathologize difference." And, as Mary Bucholtz (2019) explained, when whiteness is

[8] DuBois 1940/2011; Omi and Winant 2014; Painter 2011.

[9] See Hill 1998, 2008; Rosa and Díaz 2020; Rosa and Flores 2020; Spears 1999, 2020.

[10] See, for example, the scholarship of Mary Bucholtz, Paul Kroskrity, Ana Celia Zentella, Cecilia Cutler, Janet McIntosh, Jennifer Roth-Gordon, Nelson Flores, Lanita Jacobs, Jonathan Rosa, Hilary Dick, Jamie Thomas, Kendra Calhoun, Miyako Inoue, Sherina Feliciano-Santos, deandre miles-hercules, and Jamaal Muwwakkil.

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attended to, especially in popular discourse, it may be in service to maintaining White Supremacy through the performance of a vulnerable or "wounded" white positionality.

Careful attention to broader context, and to the primacy and resourcefulness of whiteness (as a product and conduit of White Supremacy), inspired and organized a 2021 special issue of the *Journal of Linguistic Anthropology* on Language and White Supremacy in which contributing authors earnestly took up the task of examining the linguistics and discursive workings of White Supremacy and the myriad forms of coloniality and antiblackness it has engendered (Smalls et al. 2021). Like Hill's and others' body of work, such scholarship helps us to better connect the dots between a heinous system of White Supremacy, the structures it engenders, and everyday practices.

Raciolinguistic Ideologies and the Raciolinguistic Perspective In 2015, Nelson Flores and Jonathan Rosa introduced the concept "raciolinguistic ideologies" in order to emphasize and provide precise terminology for the ideological co-naturalization and co-articulation of language and race (Flores and Rosa 2015; Rosa and Flores 2017, 2020). Their concept allows us to consider, for example, a common assumption of languages deemed "creoles" as dumbed down (or simplified) versions of a European language (e.g., Jamaican Patois, African American English/Language, Hawaiian Pidgin/Hawai'i Creole English) as an expression of a language ideology that likely emerges from and/or reifies racial ideologies about Black and other Indigenous peoples as intellectually inferior. This particular kind of raciolinguistic ideology, like most things we extract from the social world and name as ideological, actually laminates several ideological frameworks about language and race and does so in ways that help buttress one another.

As part of their effort to offer decolonial and decolonizing tools to students and scholars of language (professional and lay), Rosa and Flores show us how language ideologies about and within racially marginalized/oppressed communities in the United States are configured within specific forms of racism, specific forms that they and others tell us are situated within/under/against White Supremacy and/as coloniality (2017; Rutazibwa 2020). Specifically, the "raciolinguistic perspective" (Rosa and Flores 2017) that they propose urges not only a painstaking, and painful, examination of prevalent ways of thinking about, listening to, sorting, and treating people who are racialized as other than white (i.e., the global majority in terms of racial ontologies), but also how those ways are colonial (as in, tethered to European and US empire) and historical (as in, situated in history). Picking up Miyako Inuoue's concept of the "listening subject" (Inoue 2003), they implore us to turn our analytical gaze to those who help determine how others are heard (and seen, Rosa 2019) and to the ideological structures that shape their determinations. Alongside others, we echo that the context of various racisms (or racial orders) usually entails the spatially and temporally expansive, inextricable, and mated structures of racial slavery and European settler colonialism.[11] Evident throughout Rosa and Flores' collaborative work, and in the work of most Black and/or Indigenous scholars and other scholars of color, is that these processes of racialization occur within the spacetime of White Supremacy, colonialism, and racial slavery (i.e., within the historical context of modern race). And, while we suggest a wide spatiotemporal reach of White Supremacy vis-a-vis European modernity that must be accounted for, we also recognize that the categories implicitly or explicitly imposed by these structures (or structuring principles) can be configured differently in different contexts, or, as Harrison stated, that: "Although the multiplicity of local and national racisms cannot be

[11] Clarke and Thomas 2006; Davis and Smalls 2021; King 2019.

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reduced to a uniform Western racial hegemony, neither can they be separated from Western cultural influence" (1995, p. 50)—or from the political-economic logics of Western (European-cum-US) imperialism.

In addition to race and language studies that center verbal language, some scholarship specifically considers the role of racialized bodies and other non-linguistic signs in semiotic mediation, via a racial semiotics, or "raciosemiotics" (Smalls 2020; forthcoming) (Rosa 2019).

Key Approach: Indigenous and Decolonizing Approaches

Much of the work of Indigenous approaches to language and racism has focused on the often taken for granted narratives about Native American and Indigenous peoples, especially as they are mediated by or channeled through ideologies about language. These narratives typically rely on "Native American" as a racial formation and position Native American and Indigenous languages—and the peoples who speak them—through frameworks of "extinction," "failing," "endangerment," and "lasting."[12] Indigenous approaches have also exposed linguistic anthropology's (and other fields of language study) role in creating, holding up, and circulating such narratives and discourses—especially through the frameworks of "Salvage Anthropology"[13] which imagine language or linguistic data to be separate from, and separable from the communities that speak, have spoken, or may speak those languages again. They also disrupt commonly-held notions that linguistic anthropology, and closely related fields like linguistics, are somehow separate from and therefore not accountable for settler colonial practices of land theft, the collection of human remains, and ethnographic collections (Davis and Smalls 2021). This attention to the many machinations of settler colonialism has meant examining Indigeneity and its relationship to race, and also naming White Supremacy and examining how various modes of white normativity have depended on and sustained the disposability of Native American people, languages, cultures, and sovereignty. In addition, Indigenous approaches have called on scholars for several decades to decolonize their research practices by using collaborative research methods, and learning from Indigenous methodologies. These approaches also urge the refusal of narratives of the inevitable disappearance or demise of Indigenous peoples and/or our languages and offer frameworks for language survivance, reclamation, and Indigenous language futurities, as tools for centering Indigenous epistemologies and perspectives in research about Indigenous peoples.[14]

Key Concept: Mock Language

First introduced in Jane Hill's research on Mock Spanish, mock language is the use of appropriated (interethnic) semiotic resources from languages or varieties associated with racialized populations to display covert racism through the reproduction of negative stereotypes.[15] The use of mock language thus positions those languages (and their speakers) as both (racio)linguistically marked and un-American (in the context of the US) or un-white. This type of language use is pervasive and found in everything from casual conversations to film, television, and social media to greeting cards and business names and in settings both

[12] Leonard 2007, 2020, 2021, Meek 2011, 2020, Davis 2017a,b, 2021, Perley 2012.

[13] See for discussion Leonard 2020, 2021; Davis 2017a,b; Perley 2012.

[14] Davis 2017a,b, 2018; Leonard 2020; Leonard and Haynes 2010; Miller et al. 2021.

[15] See Barrett 2006; Bucholtz and Lopez 2011; Chun 2010, 2016; Hill 1995, 1998, 2008; Meek 2006, 2020; Mendoza-Denton 2017; Rosa 2016; Roth-Gordon 2016; Zentella 2003.

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explicitly connected to the populations being mocked—like Mock Spanish used in a Mexican restaurant (detailed in Barrett 2006)—and in those with no obvious connection.

Critically, mock registers usually operate at the level of broad ethnoracial categories, rather than of specific languages or nationalities. In fact, the erasure or blurring of those specificities is often a key feature of these registers and aids in their ability to racialize. For example, a speaker may produce a Mock (East) Asian way of speaking to mock an East Asian person of any ethnicity, maybe calling it "Chinese," rather than produce Mock Korean or Mock Cantonese and in this way, lump all East Asian languages and people together to construct a racialized grouping for which ethnic or other distinctions therein are not relevant. Similarly, Mock American Indian English (or Hollywood Injun English, per Meek 2006) exists rather than Mock Lakota or Mock Choctaw and uses features from across a wide array of (often unrelated) languages or makes up features and words altogether. This practice of consolidating and genericizing significantly different languages in order to perform and help reify (that is, make into a thing that feels real) a type of person relies heavily on raciolinguistic ideologies (as previously defined). Along with the irrelevance of ethnic and other distinctions, knowledge of the syntactical, phonological, or lexical systems of languages and people being mocked becomes irrelevant because the goal is for broad recognizability and as a result, those linguistic systems are reduced to being insignificant, disorderly, and easily available for the purposes of entertainment and ridicule. Not only is accuracy not the intent or concern of the users of mock varieties, they may be intentionally inaccurate in order to position languages like Spanish and African American English as marginal, linguistically unsophisticated, and readily available for outgroup consumption (such as when one deploys the common Mock Spanish practices of adding an "o" to English words ("el cheapo") or hyper-anglicizing Spanish words (i.e., "grassy-ass")).

Mock language then, is typically reproduced via, and helps produce structures of racism. What mock varieties "do" depends on how the languages and varieties (and critically, their speakers) are positioned within hierarchies of race[16] and who produces them. For example, Rosa (2016) demonstrates that Mock Spanish does not impact nor refer universally to all Spanish or Spanish-heritage speakers, but rather those racialized as Latinx (i.e. not Spanish from Spain), thus, Mock Spanish within the context of the United States is more about reinforcing designations of populations as not-white than not-English speaking.

Indexicality Integral to an understanding of mock language, the analytic concept "indexicality" helps us connect linguistic signs (words, pronunciations, whole languages, gestures, etc.) to meanings at play beyond denotational glosses (e.g., dictionary definitions), the immediate context of use, or a speaker/user's intentions (Ochs 1990; Silverstein 2003). That is to say, indexicality (non-referential indexicality, in particular) is a way of talking about how a sign points to a meaning (or several meanings) that may not be easily identified. These meanings often rely on and help structure social positions, sometimes by helping someone perform a certain social type (like an "educated person" or "political pundit") and, by contradistinction to the type being performed, help construct another person as a similar or other type. Jane Hill, following Elinor Ochs' formulation of "direct" and "indirect indexicality" (Ochs 1990) explained how Mock Spanish can simultaneously index different social meanings (Hill 1995). For example, saying "Grassy-ass" (a hyperanglicized pronunciation of the Spanish word *gracias*) to thank someone may directly index a humorous social type, a cosmopolitan social type, or a familiarity with Spanish and may indirectly construct Spanish (and its speakers) as "objects of derision" (Hill 1995, p. 206). Uses of Mock Spanish, and other mock varieties by extension, also indirectly index a kind of social distance between stereotypical speakers of the mocked language and the speaker using the mock variety.

[16] See Rosa 2016.

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A Brief Look at Black and Native (Dis)Possession via Language in Digital Life

In order to demonstrate the ways these approaches and concepts (alongside others) help elucidate connections between language and racism in everyday life, we will spend the remainder of this chapter applying a raciolinguistic and raciosemiotic approach to look at mock language in the online game *World of Warcraft* (WoW). We flag the ways these uses index and/or mediate raciolinguistic ideologies via discursive gaming practices which help perpetuate White Supremacist constructions of Black (specifically Afro-Caribbean and African American) and Native American and Indigenous people in North America. We situate specific practices of temporarily wearing/inhabiting/performing Black and Native people in the "massive multiplayer role-playing online game" (MMRPOG) WoW within an American[17] traditional practice of Black and Native dispossession undergirded by racial slavery and settler colonialism. We consider how the "cyber colonial" (Pressnell 2013) social world depicted in WoW through its lore, visual design, and gameplay offers tools, instructions, and permission to carry out what Smalls calls "body snatching" (2019), which encompasses a wide range of practices of dispossession (e.g., mock language, language appropriation, cultural appropriation, blackface, redface, blackphishing, mascotry).

Building out from Davis's ongoing research on race, language, and WoW (2017a), this section examines how "off-line" raciolinguistic ideologies are central to the creation of one of the most extensively played digital games in the world (and the most popular MMORPG (https://www.pcgamesn.com/10-best-pc-mmos)). With more than 100 million accounts created over the game's lifetime and an average of 5 to 6 million active accounts at any given time (Sarkar 2014), the WoW gaming universe offers high levels of player customization and variation in the gameplay experience including: movement between 1st person and 3rd person player vantage point; PvE (player versus the environment), PvP (player versus player), and role-playing servers; combinations of avatars across gender, race, and class; and a range of modes of sociality occurring in online and offline contexts in player guilds, raid parties, conventions, discussion forums, Fandom sites, etc. All of these experiences interface with the WoW digital domain and its visual and auditory representations, place names, and scripted non-player character interactions and pre-set quest options.

The digital world of *World of Warcraft* is called Azeroth[18] and is populated by eleven playable races of humanoids which inform every aspect of gameplay. Both individual gameplay and interactions between players are centered around constant inter-racial antagonism and alliance. While the races in WoW represent a range of species from mundane Humans to fantasy elves to anthropomorphic pandas and cows, many of these races are created through the deployment of mock representations of the linguistic and semiotic characteristics of broad "real-world" ethnoracial groups (Davis 2017a, 2017b; Langer 2008). From the names and language practices of non-player characters (NPCs) and place names that shape the digital linguistic landscape to the ways players themselves take up these mock linguistic practices both inside and outside of the game, WoW sociality provides examples of language and racial conflation across semiotic domains that demonstrate the role of language as a primary means of creating a racialized digital fantasy world that mirrors that of the offline world. And, in doing so, it maintains digital gaming worlds as "white public

[17] These ideologies and practices drawn mostly from the United States, but also reflect those throughout the continental Americas to some extent.

[18] Later expansions added an additional world, Outland, and the Shadowlands realm.

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space" (Hill 1998), or as spaces in which white normativity and Supremacy are effectively maintained.

When starting WoW, players choose between two factions before creating their online character: the Alliance ("resilient," "just," and "ambitious" Humans who use an unmarked Standard American English and their allies whose semiotic repertoires draw mainly from the British Isles) or the Horde (centered around a twice enslaved "foreign race" corrupted by a demon-god and their allies whose semiotic repertoires map primarily to minoritized ethnoracial groups in North America) (https://wowpedia.fandom.com/wiki/Human#Culture). We focus our attention on two Horde mock languages that are combined with a semiotic pastiche of racial stereotypes: the languaging of the Trolls, who use a mock English-related creole (Mock Jamaican Patois); and that of the Tauren, who use a mock American Indian English.[19]

Noble Savages and Mighty Warriors: Tauren Racial Discourse

The majority of players in the US play for the Alliance as Humans (Nardi 2010), but a much smaller subset of players select Tauren characters, a Horde race of anthropomorphic bovine who live on "the Tundra." They speak in Mock American Indian English, or "Hollywood Injun English" (HIE) (Meek 2006). HIE is characterized by lexical items like *Cochise*, *How!*, *Wounded Knee*, *Chief*, and *Last Mohican* and "the sprinkling of nature metaphors throughout a character's dialogue" (p. 94). Tauren NPCs have stereotypical names (Cairne Bloodhoof or Brave Cloudmane) and topics of conversation, often linked to nature, being warriors, or shamanism which is combined with a semiotic pastiche of Native American stereotypes. Most Tauren players start off in Camp Narache, Mulgore, with an introductory video that slowly sweeps closer to a Tauren village with tall totem poles and housing structures that are a mash-up of teepees and longhouses. As the view approaches the center of the village, the viewer sees an anthropomorphic cow wearing a large feather headdress and standing in front of multiple cairns holding the wrapped remains of deceased Taurens. The video is accompanied by a voiceover describing Tauren personhood, culture, and history to construct "bestial" and "noble" "warriors" and "hunters" and "child{ren} of the Earth Mother."

Thus, this opening narrative and accompanying video invites players to embody their Tauren avatars and engage with the Tauren landscape through the use of lexical items stereotypically associated with Native Americans. As players of Tauren avatars interact with their digital environment, they encounter place names such as Camp Narache, Thunderbluff, Hunter's Hill, Red Cloud Mesa, and Bloodhoof Village while the screen identifies non-player characters, or NPCs, as "wounded brave" or "fledgling brave." Some are identified with specific names and levels for those playing in Player Versus Player mode, such as "Brave Running Wolf (level 95 elite)," "Ruul Eagletalon," and "Brave Rainchaser." For their first quest, Tauren players interact with Chief Hawkwind, who is standing in front of a large funeral pyre with a wrapped Tauren body on top as other Tauren and a pandaren monk stand nearby while background music and the sound of someone weeping play in the

[19] There is also a later-added race of anthropomorphic pandas, the Pandaren who use a Mock Asian (Chun 2010) variety. The Pandaren are the only race that can be either Alliance or Horde; Blizzard describes them as an "enigmatic" people with a "noble history" that "stretches back thousands of years" (https://worldofwarcraft.com/en-us/game/races/pandaren), perhaps reflecting a particular kind of othering reserved for East Asian people in the White Supremacist imaginary. Mink Choi, a Korean American book publisher and long-time WoW player shared in a 2014 NPR article that: "Yes, giant pandas that belong to clans with Chinese-sounding names and lands filled with 'Asian' architecture" (Demby 2014).

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background. Chief Hawkwind, when activated by players, greets them with "Well met," and then "How!"—the second of seven different greetings that represent the NPC greeting repertoire of all Taurens. Importantly, all Tauren quests and NPCs deploy HIE features—the latter even when interacting with non-Tauren characters in the game. As such, all players playing Horde characters, and many playing Alliance characters, will encounter this mock Native linguistic representation.

Violent Savages and Dark Magic: Troll Racial Discourse

WoW's website tells us that "The savage trolls of Azeroth are infamous for their cruelty, dark mysticism, and seething hatred for the other races," establishing them as a particular kind of savage quite distinct from the Tauren. We are also told that the race has been "plagued by a history of subservience and exile" (https://worldofwarcraft.com/en-us/game/races/troll).

While Human NPCs have names like "Benjamin Foxworthy," "Merissa Stilwell," and "Marcus Jensen," and offer programmed greetings of "hey there" and "good day to you," in towns with names like Goldshire, Troll NPCs, in contrast, bear names that incorporate non-human animalistic features (which often index their non-human physiological traits) such as "Lar Prowltusk," "Vel'rin Fang," and "Chief Ukorz Sandscalp." The tusked, long-armed, strong-legged beings frequently greet players with "Greetings, *mon*," and "Spirits be wit ya, *mon*." Like the Tauren, they are organized into tribes but dwell in mostly tropical settings called Sen'jin Village and Darkspear Isle. Many Troll names also index a stereotypical "traditional African" phonology and morphology that seems to be based on Bantu languages' agglutinative structures that feature multiple short open syllables (namely, Consonant-Vowel clusters) (e.g., "Una Kobuna," "Unjari (Feltongue)," "Ruuzulu").

In general, Troll language use includes the highly stigmatized (and usually misused) habitual aspective "be" of African American Language and related varieties, phonetic erosion (such as word-final consonant reduction and deletion), and replacing theta (/th/) with /d/. One of the most marked (indexically salient) features of Troll language, however, is the use of *mon*—a gender-neutral, highly informal, term of address—helping to construct it as a Mock Jamaican Patois. As an example, in a beginning quest for people playing Hunter Troll avatars, players are addressed as *mon* and then are given instructions to learn basic weaponry skills by striking targets shaped like *tiki* (Trolls' magically animated masks) in language using several of the mentioned features. With its "africanized" namings, incorporation of Oceanic cultural products (e.g., tikis), and indiscriminate uses of features from Jamaican Patois and African American Language, Troll language ways effectively index an aggregated Blackness in which ethnic distinctions are irrelevant—similar to Tauren mock language.

In a wowpedia.fandom.com guide to playing Troll, which opens with the Mock Patois introduction, "So, ya want ta be a Troll, mon?" Trolls are described as "violent and bloodthirsty" with "tribal" and "shamanastic" roots. This prologue to playing Troll (assumed to be written by an expert player) claims that the race is "based on Haitian and Jamaican cultures" and, ironically, warns players against using stereotypes "to an extreme degree" (seeming to note that some use of stereotypes is unavoidable) lest they risk appearing "racist and offensive." It then asserts—in line with several other commenters (approximately 50) we came across on this site and on WoW's discussion forum—that some other WoW races are also based on "real world cultures" *(https://wowpedia.fandom.com/wiki/How_to_roleplay_a_troll)*.

This metalinguistic account also makes pointed connections between physiological difference and/or deviance and linguistic production ("having huge tusks jutting out of

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your mouth" that are inferred to help produce the "accent"). These particular ideologies about the ways language is linked to essential difference help maintain the anti-Black raciolinguistic logics of early linguistic and ethnological theories—and enduring folk theories—about "thick lips" and varieties produced by people of recent African descent (Crawfurd 1866; Dillard 1973).

Digital (Linguistic) Role-Play as Body Snatching in the Settler–Slave State

In WoW, playable humanoid races are patently tied to colonial groupings based on biological, geographic, and linguistic mappings of race. This is done through explicit expressions of racial stereotypes about dispositions, traits, spiritual practices, and perhaps most concretely, language. By formulating typical linguistic practices for each race through NPCs' verbal interactions, the game invites players to mimic the NPCs as they (players) digitally perform and embody racialized figures, thereby rendering mock language a means to lay claim to (or snatch) these racialized figures and real racialized groups they index. This role of mock language in digital gaming is far from exceptional: as in other mediated and non-digital contexts, it plays an essential role in the circulation of racialized varieties and the formation of white public space.[20] In particular, these mock varieties reinforce particular "common sense" expectations about racialized groups and function as registers in many ways (Agha 2005). *World of Warcraft* is especially robust, however, to the extent that it invites players to be both the direct interlocutors and producers of these racialized varieties. It is also notable due to the sheer amount of exposure to these varieties players and spectators get in terms of number of players worldwide and hours logged among them.

As Meek notes in her discussion of the role of these types of representations in the larger public perceptions of Native Americans, "for non-Native audiences, the logics derive primarily from mass-mediated experiences rather than real-life interactions" (2020, p. 374). Mock language in World of Warcraft makes the races inherently, and audibly, different from each other (and from the players themselves) on the one hand, but sufficiently close to English[21] to make them portable and snatchable by players.

When situated within the ongoing processes of racial slavery and settler colonialism,[22] roleplay practices like those in WoW—when used by non-Black and non-Native US-based players, especially—become more than racial, but also categorically racist and colonial and White Supremacist. That is to say, pretending to be a symbolically Black or Native American character that is based on largely harmful and dehumanizing stereotypes when you do not identify as either is not just a racializing practice or event but a deeply racist one. In the context of the settler–slave state, we consider these kinds of role-playing practices, articulated largely through language use, as extensions of a historical praxis of body snatching (Smalls 2019) which permeates the activities of this nation-state and much of the modern world.

Using a raciosemiotics approach, Smalls has defined body snatching as an expansive set of *symbolic practices of embodied dispossession*, or semiotic means through which racialized bodies and embodied practices are stolen from certain kinds of subjugated groups by members of dominant groups (2019). Body snatching is, in many ways, a reformulation of linguistic and cultural appropriation, as they have come to be used in popular discourse, that emphasizes the connection between the historical and ongoing theft of literal bodies

[20] See Barrett 2006; Bucholtz and Lopez 2011; Hill 1995, 1998, 2008.

[21] WoW can also be played in other languages, depending on geographic location and player choice.

[22] Hartman 2007; Sharpe 2016; Simpson 2014.

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(e.g., enslavement, scalping, incarceration, kidnapping, grave robbing, gene theft, postmortem theft) and the unconsented use of embodied practices from groups who have been historically subjugated largely *because* of the ways their bodies have been constructed by dominant schemas (Davis and Smalls 2021). In this way, certain bodies are treated as highly "entextualizable"—that is, made into an extractable and moveable text via a semiotic process called "entextualization" (Bauman and Briggs 1990; Urban and Silverstein 1996) that can be used without the consent of the subjects that inhabit them (Smalls, forthcoming). In tandem, embodied practices like language, dance (and movement, in general), and spiritual practices can be extracted (dispossessed) and contextualized (repossessed) by others.

In several ways, body snatching renders Black and Native personhood a *thing* that can be easily disposed of, so that Black and Native bodies, once emptied of personhood, can be more easily dissected, replaced, mocked, worn, or rendered caricatures of real Humans. Both forms of body snatching reify the notion that Black and Native bodies' value can only be fully realized when owned, or inhabited i.e., (re)possessed (Moreton-Robinson 2016), by a proper Human subject—and both flag the peculiar bearing of Black and Native dispossession in the making of the US settler–slave state and in particular, in the construction of the white American citizen-subject. Body snatching allows non-Black and non-Native players to digitally wear and inhabit Blackness and/or Nativeness while maintaining ontological distance in multiple ways—with the use of mock language being one notable example. With its default Human as prototypically white and American (with a Standard American English accent), detailed lore and racial descriptions throughout its cultural architecture, customizability of avatars, and the ability to actually "play Indian" (Deloria 2007) or perform "digital blackface" (Parham 2020) with others through the use of mock languages in gameplay and chat, WoW follows Disney (Lippi-Green 1997) as a powerful pedagogue of White Supremacy a la US empire, regardless of players' ethnoracial or national backgrounds.[23]

Language and Race/ism: Future Directions

While the historical trajectories in which various ethnoracial structures exist are different and complex, most—if not all—pass through and/or are impacted by racialized modernity (Hesse 2007) as a structuring paradigm. This means that when we, as scholars of language, culture, and society, are looking at any aspect of human life after the fifteenth century, we are also dealing with White Supremacy, antiblackness, and anti-Indigeneity (whether we attend to them or not). To put it very plainly, this means that any sociocultural structure or practice in any part of the world touched by European modernity—that is to say, any contemporary context—is situated within the global structure of coloniality and, specifically, within "the coloniality of power" (Lugones 2007; Quijano 2000), "modernity/coloniality" (Mignolo 2006; Quijano 2007), or the "coloniality of being/power/truth/freedom" (Wynter 2003) articulated through European colonialism (among others).

By situating everyday discursive racializing practices like those in WoW within relevant historical context, we hope to show that modern race is historical in that it is not a fixed universal

[23] There are a growing number of conversations (e.g., subReddits, blogs, articles) that are examining WoW's possible role as a breeding ground for White Supremacist ideologies. A 2021 article by Steve Messner for pggamer.com reviews some of these allegations: https://www.pcgamer.com/world-of-warcrafts-community-is-grappling-with-allegations-of-widespread-racism-in-its-top-end-raiding-guilds.

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feature of human life, but rather a persistent global pattern in recent history (Lowe 2015). We also stress that because modern race (in its varied manifestations) helps shape the political, social, cultural context that most language scholars encounter in their studies, it is important that rather than invoke "race" or "racism" as generic concepts that derive meaning solely at a local or regional scale (that is autonomous or discrete from others) or solely on an interactional scale, scholars who are compelled toward anti-racist work or toward better understandings of race should take it up as a historical and global racial hierarchy which impacts most local structures of social organization and micro interactions. Even when sociolinguistic practices or ideologies are not as plainly derivative of European modernity's racial order as in WoW, scholars who take up race, racialization, or racism in language studies are responsible for accounting for White Supremacy (via coloniality/modernity), antiblackness (via racial slavery), and anti-Indigeneity (via settler colonialism) as global and historical structures, and for deeply citing Black, Native, and people of color scholars who have studied these phenomena, less they run the risk of producing knowledge that is not only inadequate, but also harmful in many cases.

From this understanding, we echo many scholars (see Charity Hudley et al. 2020) before and beside us who consider the stakes for producing knowledge about language, culture, and society to be extremely high for Black, Indigenous, and people of color folx throughout the world. The reverberating impact of anthropology, linguistics, and other social sciences on our lives cannot be accurately measured but most of us feel it daily: in the ways our words are interpreted, the ways our bodies are treated, how our practices are taken (up) (Davis and Smalls 2021). Therefore, as more Black, Indigenous, and people of color scholars enter the subfield, we are seeing a linguistic anthropology that stands on what Alessandro Duranti anticipated as a possible fourth paradigm shift—which reaches deeper into race, gender, and queer theory to continue the work of our scholarly forebearers of terminating common questions and approaches and further blurring the boundaries around what we understand to be "linguistic anthropology" (Duranti 2003). We understand these ruptures and new beginnings to be moves toward language and culture scholarship that is in service to the protection and celebration of Black and Native people and all marginalized peoples.[24]

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[24] Davis and Smalls 2021; Leonard 2021; Smalls et al. 2021.

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